Guidelines for Septic and Onsite Wastewater Systems

For Everyone

AUG. 24, 2026, VISIT LINK FOR DETAILS.

KEY POINTS

- Heavy rains, severe flooding, or other types of emergency events could damage sewer systems and cause an overflow of untreated wastewater into communities and the environment.
- Know how to protect your septic or onsite wastewater system from damage caused by heavy rains, floods, or other emergencies.

Overview



Know how to protect your septic system from damage caused by floods and other disasters.

Heavy rains, severe flooding, or other types of emergency events

could damage sewer systems and cause an overflow of untreated wastewater into communities and the environment.

Warning!

Always avoid contact with any floodwater that may be contaminated with sewage— it can make you sick!

Maintain your septic system to prevent damage from heavy rains or floods.

A well-maintained and constructed septic system will better withstand the stresses of heavy rains or flooding. Regular inspection is necessary to ensure proper functioning. During heavy rains and floods, the ground can become saturated, preventing proper operation of the system. For example, a septic tank can collapse or float out of position.

Signs that a septic system is not working properly include the following:

- Sinks drain slowly

- Toilets drain slowly
- Floor drains overflow
- Sewage becomes visible outside the home

For more information about septic systems, see the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency's (EPA) Managing Septic Systems to Prevent Contamination of Drinking Water.

Protect your septic and onsite wastewater systems

Before an emergency

To prepare your septic system before an emergency such as a flood, hurricane, or earthquake:

- Seal the manhole and/or inspection ports to keep excess water out of the septic tank
- Be sure your septic tank is at least half full to prevent it from collapsing or floating
- If your septic system requires electricity:
  - Turn off the pump at the circuit box before the area floods.
  - Waterproof all electrical connections to avoid electrical

shock or damage to wiring, pumps, and the electrical system.

During an emergency

- During an emergency such as a flood, hurricane, or earthquake, reduce the amount of water used by limiting toilet flushing, dishwashing, washing clothes, and showering.
- Severe flooding can put drinking water wells at increased risk for contamination from flood water that may contain sewage. Avoid contact with any standing water that may contain sewage.

After an emergency

Be aware that flood water may contain sewage.

Caution!

Do not drink well water until you know it is safe. Use a safe water supply like bottled or treated water learn how to make water safe.

KEEP READINGSafety Guidelines: Floodwater

Take the following precautions:

- Avoid contact with any septic system electrical devices until they are dry and clean.
- Do not pump out the septic tank more than halfway or the tank may float out of the ground.
- Reduce all nonessential water use (for example, dishwashing, washing clothes, showering).
- Flush toilets as little as possible or use a temporary toilet.

If you suspect septic system damage, get the system professionally inspected and serviced. Contact your health department for a list of septic system contractors who work in your area.

Resources

- CDC. Potential Sanitation Solutions During an Emergency Response
- National Environmental Services Center. First Aid for a Flooded Septic System
- EPA. Septic Systems – What to Do After a Flood

- EPA. Emergency Response for Drinking Water and Wastewater Utilities
- EPA. Septic (Onsite) Systems, Tools and Resources
- Cornell University. Water Quality Information for Consumers: Septic Systems and Wastewater
- Public Works Group. Video: Demo of Sewer Backflow Prevention Device.
- FEMA. Install Sewer Backflow Valves
- Water Environment Research Foundation. Emergency Response Plan Guidance for Wastewater Systems

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KEY POINTS

- Never drive in flooded areas—turn around, don't drown!
- Stay out of floodwater—it can contain many things that can hurt you or make you sick.

Overview



Never drive in flooded areas—turn around, don't drown!

Floodwater and standing water can be dangerous and can make you vulnerable to infectious diseases, chemical hazards, and injuries. Protect yourself and your loved ones from the risks brought by floodwater by following these steps.

Don't drive in flooded areas.

- Always follow warnings about flooded roads.
- Don't drive in flooded areas—cars or other vehicles won't protect you from floodwaters. They can be swept away or may stall in moving water.

Turn around, don't drown!

Floodwater can pose a drowning risk for everyone— regardless of their ability to swim. Swiftly moving shallow water can be deadly, and even shallow standing water can be dangerous for small children.

Stay out of floodwater

Floodwaters contain many things that may harm health.

Be Ready! Floods Infographic

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We don't know exactly what is in floodwater at any given point in time. Floodwater can contain:

- Downed power lines
- Human and livestock waste
- Household, medical, and industrial hazardous waste (chemical, biological, and radiological)

- Coal ash waste that can contain carcinogenic compounds such as arsenic, chromium, and mercury
- Other germs and contaminants that can lead to illness
- Physical objects such as lumber, vehicles, and debris
- Wild or stray animals such as rodents and snakes

Exposure to contaminated floodwater can cause:

- Wound infections
- Skin rash
- Gastrointestinal illness
- Tetanus
- Leptospirosis (not common)
- Melioidosis (along the Gulf Coast)

The best way to protect yourself is to stay out of the water.

If you come in contact with floodwater:

- Wash the area with soap and clean water as soon as possible. If you don't have soap or water, use alcohol-based wipes or sanitizer.
- Take care of wounds and seek medical attention if necessary.

- Wash clothes contaminated with flood or sewage water in hot water and detergent before reusing them.

  If you must enter floodwater, wear rubber boots, rubber gloves, and goggles.

Protect yourself from illness and injuries

Prevent injuries.

Floodwater may contain sharp objects, such as glass or metal fragments, that can cause injury and lead to infection. Prompt first aid can help heal small wounds and prevent infection.

If you receive a puncture wound or a wound contaminated with feces, soil, or saliva, have a health care professional determine whether a tetanus booster is necessary based on individual records.

KEEP READINGEmergency Wound Care After a Natural Disaster Factsheet

Prevent infection of open wounds and rashes.

Open wounds and rashes exposed to floodwater can become infected. Vibrios, for example, are naturally occurring bacteria that live in certain coastal waters and can cause skin infections when an open wound is exposed to them. This can happen during floods. To protect yourself and your family:

- Avoid exposure to floodwater if you have an open wound.
- Cover clean, open wounds with a waterproof bandage to reduce chance of infection.
- Keep open wounds as clean as possible by washing well with soap and clean water.
- If a wound develops redness, swelling, or oozing, seek immediate medical attention.

Seek medical attention as soon as possible if:

- There is a foreign object (soil, wood, metal, or other objects) embedded in the wound;

- The wound is at special risk of infection (such as a dog bite or a puncture by a dirty object);
- An old wound shows signs of becoming infected (increased pain and soreness, swelling, redness, draining, or you develop a fever).

KEEP READINGEmergency Wound Care After a Natural Disaster Factsheet

Protect yourself and your loved ones from diarrheal diseases.

Be aware that floodwater may contain sewage, and eating or drinking anything contaminated by floodwater can cause diarrheal disease (such as *E. coli* or *Salmonella* infection). To protect yourself and your family:

- Wash your hands after contact with floodwater. Also be sure to wash children's hands with soap and water often and always before meals.
- Do not allow children to play in floodwater areas.
- Do not allow children to play with toys that have been

contaminated by floodwater and have not been disinfected.

- Do not bathe in water that may be contaminated with sewage or toxic chemicals. This includes rivers, streams, or lakes that are contaminated by floodwater.

KEEP READINGWater, Sanitation, and Hygiene (WASH)-related Emergencies and Outbreaks

Protect yourself from animal and insect bites.

Floodwater can displace animals, insects, and reptiles. To protect yourself and your family, be alert and avoid contact.

KEEP READINGWhat to Do to Protect Yourself From Animals After a Disaster

Be aware of possible chemicals in floodwater.

Floods can cause containers of chemicals to move from their normal storage spots. Protect yourself from chemicals released during a natural disaster.

- Don't attempt to move propane tanks you might find— they're dangerous and can cause a fire or explosion. If you find any, contact the police, fire department, or your State Fire Marshal's office immediately.
- Be extremely careful when removing car batteries. Even if they are in floodwater, car batteries may still have an electrical charge. Use insulated gloves and avoid coming in contact with any acid that may have spilled from the damaged car battery.

KEEP READINGAbout Chemical Emergencies

Avoid electrical hazards inside or outside your home.

After a hurricane, flood or other natural disaster you need to be careful to avoid electrical hazards both in your home and elsewhere.

- Shut off electrical power and natural gas or propane tanks in your home to avoid fire, electrocution, or explosions.

- NEVER touch a fallen power line. Call the power company to report fallen power lines. Avoid contact with overhead power lines during cleanup and other activities.
- Do not drive through standing water if downed power lines are in the water.
- If you believe someone has been electrocuted, call or have someone else call 911 or emergency medical help.

KEEP READINGWhat to Do to Protect Yourself From Electrical Hazards

Resources

- Natural Disasters and Severe Weather
- Flood Safety and Preparedness (weather.gov)
- Flood Safety | Flood Preparedness | American Red Cross
- Floods | Ready.gov

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